

PHASE 4

CREATING A RECORD PRODUCER

Turning the Employee Issue table into a guided, catalog-driven intake experience employees can actually use.

Employee Raise Issue — ServiceNow Implementation Guide
Standalone Phase Document 4 of 7

Document Version 1.0

About This Document

This document is a standalone, self-contained implementation guide for Phase 4 — Creating a Record Producer — of the Employee Raise Issue project. It can be read and actioned on its own, without needing the full multi-phase master documentation, though it references the wider project for context where useful.

Field	Detail
Application	Employee Raise Issue (built within the Employee Center scope)
Phase	Phase 4 of 7
Primary Owner	Service Catalog Administrator
Related Document	Employee Raise Issue Documentation (full 7-phase project reference)
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1. Purpose and Scope

This document is the complete, standalone implementation guide for Phase 4 of the Employee Raise Issue project: building the Record Producer that employees actually interact with. It assumes Phases 1–3 are complete — a scoped application, a fielded Employee Issue table, and working UI Policies/dependencies all exist.

By the end of this phase, employees can raise an issue through a simplified, guided catalog item rather than a raw table form, with variables mapped correctly onto the underlying table and the dynamic behavior from Phase 3 reproduced at the catalog level.

2. Where This Phase Fits in the Project

- Depends on: the Employee Issue table and fields (Phase 2), and the UI Policy logic (Phase 3), which this phase reproduces as Catalog UI Policies.
- Feeds into: Phase 5's Service Portal, which hosts this Record Producer inside a dedicated Raise an Issue page, and Phase 6's widgets, which link directly to it.
- Verified by: Phase 7's functional test cases (TC-04 specifically exercises a full, valid submission through this Record Producer).

3. Objective

Rather than exposing the Employee Issue table directly through a standard form, employees should interact with a Record Producer — a Service Catalog item that presents a simplified, guided intake experience and creates a record on the target table upon submission.

4. Why a Record Producer Instead of a Direct Table Form

Concern	Direct Table Form	Record Producer
Employee-facing simplicity	Shows every field on the table, including system-managed ones	Shows only the variables you choose to expose, in the order you choose
Catalog discoverability	Not searchable through the Service Catalog	Appears in catalog search and category browsing
Reusable dynamic behavior	Relies solely on table-level UI Policies	Supports its own Catalog UI Policies and Catalog Client Scripts, independent of the agent-facing form
Approval workflow readiness	Requires custom scripting to attach an approval flow	Integrates naturally with Flow Designer / Workflow for future approval needs
Fulfillment reporting	Not tracked as catalog fulfillment	Tracked alongside other catalog requests for reporting

5. Prerequisites

- Phases 1–3 complete.
- A Service Catalog and Category identified to host this item (for example, an existing Employee Self-Service catalog and a Services or Workplace Support category).

- Agreement on the minimum set of variables an employee should be asked to complete, distinct from the full field list on the table (see section 6).

6. Step-by-Step Configuration

1. Navigate to Service Catalog > Catalog Definitions > Record Producers, or create one from within Studio as an application file.
2. Set Name to Raise Employee Issue.
3. Set Table name to Employee Issue [the table created in Phase 2].
4. Assign the item to an appropriate Catalog and Category, for example: Service Catalog > Services.
5. Write a clear, employee-facing Short description, e.g. "Raise a hardware, software, network, or access issue and get help from the right team."
6. Set What it will contain to describe the intake form, and What it will replace if this Record Producer supersedes an existing manual process.
7. Under Variables, add one catalog variable per field the employee should complete. In the working build this included: requester name (Reference), category (Multiple Choice), short description (Single Line Text), subcategory (Multiple Choice), and state (Multiple Choice).
8. For each variable, set the Question, Type, Mandatory flag, and Order.
9. Map each variable to its corresponding table field so the value flows automatically into the created record.
10. Add Variable Sets where appropriate to group related fields (for example, an "Issue Details" set containing Category, Subcategory, and Priority).
11. Configure Catalog UI Policies on the Record Producer mirroring the logic built in Phase 3 (category-driven subcategory, conditional attachment requirement, conditional contact method).
12. Set the Script field (Producer script) to populate any fields not directly mapped from variables, such as defaulting Requester to the requesting user and setting the initial State to New.
13. Configure Redirect to a confirmation page or the newly created record, so the employee receives immediate confirmation their issue was logged.
14. Set Active to true and confirm the Application field shows the correct scope.

The screenshot shows the 'Record Producer' configuration page for a 'New record'. The form includes the following fields and options:

- Name:** Raise Employee Issue
- * Table name:** Employee raises issue [sn_ex_sp_e...]
- Application:** Employee Center
- Active:** ☒
- State:** -- None --
- Checked out:** -- None --
- Owner:** System Administrator

Below the form, there are four tabs: 'What it will contain', 'Accessibility' (highlighted with a green border), 'Generated Record Data', and 'Portal Settings'. The 'Accessibility' tab is active, showing the following configuration:

- Catalogs:** Service Catalog
- Category:** Services
- View:** (empty field)
- Can cancel:** ☐

Figure 5 — Raise Employee Issue record producer configuration, linked to the Employee raises issue [sn_ex_sp_e...] table, filed under the Services category of the Service Catalog.

7. Screenshot Reference

Figure 5 shows the Record Producer's core configuration: its Name, Table name, Application, and Active flag, alongside the Accessibility tab controlling which Catalog and Category it appears under. Figure 6 below shows the resulting variable list as configured on the working instance.

The screenshot shows the 'Variables' tab with a table of configured variables. The table has columns for Question, Field, Type, and Order.

Question	Field	Type	Order
What is the requester name?	u_reference_1	Reference	
Which category?	u_choice_2	Multiple Choice	
Short Description	u_string_4	Single Line Text	
What is subcategory ?	u_choice_3	Multiple Choice	
Which state is this issue?	u_choice_5	Multiple Choice	

The table is displayed on a page with 5 rows, showing row 1 of 5.

Figure 6 — Catalog variables configured on the Raise Employee Issue record producer: requester name (Reference), category and subcategory (Multiple Choice), short description (Single Line Text), and state (Multiple Choice).

NOTE: The record producer is named *Raise Employee Issue* in the working build. Its Requester and State variables give the employee more visibility and control over the submitted request than a minimal variable set would; weigh this against the abandonment risk discussed in section 13 when deciding how much to expose.

8. Sample Producer Script

The following logic (conceptually, not verbatim production code) executes on submission to finalize the record before it is inserted:

- Set current.requester to the requesting user if the variable was left blank.
- Set current.department by looking up the user's department record.
- Set current.state to the initial New value.
- Calculate current.assignment_group from current.category using the routing logic established alongside Phase 3's server-side validation.
- Insert the record and store the resulting sys_id for the redirect/confirmation step.

WATCH OUT: Keep producer scripts focused on deriving system fields and defaults. Business logic that must also apply outside the Record Producer (for example, if a REST integration submits issues directly) belongs in a Business Rule on the table, not solely in the producer script — otherwise that logic is silently skipped for any other entry point.

9. Availability and Roles

Setting	Configuration
Active	true
Roles	None (available to all authenticated employees) or a dedicated employee self-service role
Available for	Service Portal (Phase 5) and Service Catalog (Classic UI as a fallback)
Workflow	None required for the initial build; an approval workflow for High/Critical priority issues is a documented future enhancement

9.1 Worked Example: A Submission Walkthrough

To make the configuration above concrete, the following walks through one representative submission end to end, exactly as an employee would experience it.

1. The employee opens the Service Portal and searches for "issue" or browses to Services.
2. They select Raise Employee Issue and the Record Producer form loads with its five variables.
3. They select Category = Network, and the Catalog UI Policy immediately narrows Subcategory to Network-specific values (VPN, Wi-Fi / LAN Connectivity).
4. They select Subcategory = VPN and enter a Short Description: "VPN keeps disconnecting during video calls."
5. On Submit, the Producer script sets Requester to the logged-in employee, derives Department, sets State to New, and calculates Assignment Group as IT Infrastructure.
6. The record is created (for example, EMP0000011), and the employee is redirected to a confirmation showing that number.

NOTE: This walkthrough deliberately uses the same category/subcategory pairing shown in Figure 4, so it can be reproduced step for step against the working instance during testing.

10. Catalog Placement and Discoverability

A Record Producer that employees cannot find is no better than a table form they don't know exists. Confirm the following before considering this phase complete:

- The item's Category places it somewhere an employee would naturally browse (avoid burying it several categories deep).
- The Short description uses words an employee would actually search for ("issue", "problem", "request", "help") rather than internal terminology.
- The item is not restricted by a role that excludes ordinary employees by accident.
- Portal search (verified explicitly in Phase 7) returns the item for a plain-language query.

11. Common Issues and Troubleshooting

Issue	Likely Cause	Resolution
Record Producer does not appear in catalog search	Item is inactive, restricted by role, or not assigned to a searchable category.	Confirm Active is true, review role restrictions, and confirm the category is included in portal search scope.
Variable values do not populate the created record	The variable's Name does not match the target field's column name exactly.	Re-check the variable-to-field mapping; mismatched names silently fail to populate.
Catalog UI Policy does not fire on the Record Producer	The policy was created as a table-level UI Policy instead of a Catalog UI Policy.	Recreate the rule specifically under the Record Producer's Catalog UI Policies related list.
Submission redirects to a blank or broken page	The Redirect setting points to a page or view that no longer exists.	Update Redirect to a valid, currently published page (see Phase 5 for the confirmation page).
Two employees submitting at the same time both end up assigned to the same generic group	The producer script's routing logic has a bug or missing category mapping.	Test routing for every category value explicitly, including any newly added ones.

12. Validating Phase 4 Completion

- The Record Producer appears in the Service Catalog under its assigned category and is findable via search.
- Submitting the form as a standard employee creates a correctly populated Employee Issue record.
- Catalog UI Policies reproduce the same behavior as the table-level UI Policies from Phase 3.
- The Producer script correctly derives Requester, Department, State, and Assignment Group without requiring the employee to select them manually.
- The employee is redirected to a clear confirmation showing the generated issue number.

13. Best Practices

BEST PRACTICE: Keep the Record Producer's variable set as short as possible. Every additional required field increases abandonment; where a value can be derived (Department, Assignment Group), derive it in the producer script instead of asking the employee.

BEST PRACTICE: Write the Short description and category placement from the employee's point of view, not the administrator's — think about what an employee would type into search, not what the table is called internally.

BEST PRACTICE: Keep Catalog UI Policies and table-level UI Policies (Phase 3) logically identical even though they are configured separately — document both together so a future change to one prompts a review of the other.

13.1 Frequently Asked Questions

Should employees be able to select their own Priority?

Allowing employees to self-select Priority is common but has a well-known failure mode: everything eventually becomes "Critical." Consider pairing an employee-facing urgency question with an agent-adjustable Priority field the employee cannot directly set, or provide clear, concrete definitions for each priority level directly in the variable's help text.

Can the same Record Producer be exposed in more than one catalog?

Yes — a Record Producer can be associated with multiple catalogs via its Catalogs related list, useful if, for example, both a general Employee Self-Service catalog and a dedicated IT Service catalog should surface the same item.

What happens to in-progress submissions if the Record Producer is deactivated?

Deactivating the Record Producer only affects new submissions — it is removed from catalog search and browsing, but existing Employee Issue records are unaffected and remain fully manageable by agents.

How many variables is too many?

There is no fixed number, but as a working rule of thumb, anything beyond six or seven visible fields on a single-page Record Producer is worth splitting into Variable Sets, defaulting some values instead of asking for them, or reconsidering whether every field genuinely needs to be collected at intake rather than filled in later by the assigned agent.

13.2 Terminology Used in This Phase

Term	Meaning in This Context
Record Producer	A Service Catalog item that presents a simplified intake form and creates a record on a target table when submitted.
Catalog Variable	One question/field on a Record Producer's form, mapped to a field on the target table.
Variable Set	A reusable, named group of variables that can be attached to more than one catalog item.
Catalog UI Policy	A UI Policy scoped specifically to a catalog item, distinct from a table-level UI Policy.
Producer Script	Server-side script that runs on submission to finalize the record before it is inserted.
Catalog / Category	The browsable structure employees use to find catalog items in the Service Catalog and Service Portal.

14. Summary and Handoff to Phase 5

At the end of this phase, employees have a working, discoverable, validated way to raise an issue through the Service Catalog. This Record Producer is now ready to be embedded in a dedicated employee-facing page in Phase 5 — Creating a New Service Portal — giving it a clean, branded home outside the general catalog browsing experience.

14.1 Phase 4 Deliverables Checklist

Deliverable	Status
Raise Employee Issue record producer created and active	Complete
Variables mapped correctly to table fields	Complete
Catalog UI Policies mirror Phase 3 table-level rules	Complete
Producer script derives Requester, Department, State, Assignment Group	Complete
Item placed in a discoverable catalog category	Complete
Ready for Phase 5 Service Portal integration	Ready